

Dear students!

Lilli Liçka, the head of the Institute of Landscape Architecture invited me to lead a course in contemporary landscape architecture. She is keen to promote collaborations between landscape architecture and public art. These disciplines have so much in common! Both of them create imaginative and attractive places for public life whilst respecting the nature and history of the site and the needs of both humanity and the non-humans.

I am one of the founders and partners of the artist collective Observatorium (1998, Rotterdam) and I will introduce you to ideas and experiences in the field of public art in relation to landscape architecture, social life and spatial politics. What is the function of public art in a community, how is it embedded in landscape design and ? How is it a work of art with a spell within the tensions and restrictions of public space and interest. Sometimes it takes a bold gesture in majestic landscape, in other places the work of art is part of a collaborative transition.

My theme and site for this course was chosen after spotting a large dark green area with a white cross in the middle on the map of Vienna. Is that an ensemble of a temple in an enclosed garden I am looking at? In a way, yes: the white cross is a university observatory and a landmark in the history of astrophysics and the garden is a natural landmark with restricted access! How exciting for landscape architects – the enclosed Sternwartepark was designed around an observatory and due to 100 years of neglect it became a nature reserve. How exciting for me and Observatorium – working on public art for public life.
In the future, islands of wilderness or urban forests will become a substantial part of your profession, cooling the city and providing space for wildlife. How can artistic approaches and methodologies help the landscape architect to design wilderness and create meaningful landscapes in which natural dynamics are essential. How do we create awareness for miracles happening in forbidden worlds?

The amazing story of Sternwartepark is worth telling. How do we tell it on site? What means remain if we are not allowed to add objects or make changes? Can we invent ways of maintenance that tell the story? Can we make people pause and observe while taking a walk? What more will they experience apart from enjoying the light, smell and sounds of a nature treasure? How is the park related to the universe via the observatory?

We should take a look at the tradition of creating ensembles of natural beauty and art in parks in Vienna. We could develop a list of all kinds of non-physical ways to guide our relationship to a site and to natural processes in sanctuaries. Let's design and test simple ways to enhance the respect, joy and knowlegde that Sternwartepark already entices, both inside and outside the walled area.

You may get in the mood by a stroll through the park on your own before the start of the course. Please, tell me what happened to you and send me your impressions preferably before April 22nd.

Detailled work descriptions will be shared at our first meeting at BOKU. You will work individually and your results will be presented and form the basis for your assessment. Feel free to ask both at the introductory meeting and throughout the course if anything is unclear or worth discussing. Please, make sure that you make time for this course, since your presence is required.

Bring your good spirit and dreams and let's enjoy our quest for a magical garden.
Looking forward hearing from you, kind regards,

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